DAILY READING • 样张

The Last Meeting

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短文

On the eve of his last faculty conference, Dean Alvarez read the handbook one more time. Twenty-two years inside the administration had taught him that the appropriate sentence was rarely the true one. He had sent the signal three weeks earlier, in a memo so abstract that only two people claimed to understand it. His employer was not a person but a set of procedures, and those procedures met more frequently than he did. At sixty-eight, he had learned to speak in the passive voice and to arrive early. He closed the book, turned off the lamp, and sat for a while in the dark. The building was quiet. Somewhere below him, a door closed.

At nine he stood up and pitched the plan to the committee. East Hall, empty for six years, could become housing for graduate students: forty small units, a shared kitchen, heat that worked. The estimate was massive — eight million — but the alternative was demolition at nearly the same price, and demolition would leave nothing behind. Utility costs alone were rising yearly, and slightly faster than the budget allowed. He had not advertised the idea in advance, because advertising it would have killed it; the efficient path was to let the numbers speak first. He passed the one-page summary down the table and waited. For a long moment nobody picked it up.

East Hall had been his mother's building. She had worked there for thirty years, and when she died he inherited a small antique clock from her office. It still sat in his desk drawer, and he wound it every Monday. The place had a personality no report could hold and a psychological weight that no estimate could capture. It haunted him, in the way unfinished work does. It also had a consciousness of its own, or so it seemed at six in the morning, when the radiators knocked and the corridors smelled of chalk. There had been a burial behind the building in 1958 — a groundskeeper, never recorded — and his mother had a singular way of speaking about him, tender and matter-of-fact at once.

The vote was brutal. Two members resisted for an hour, and Hollis from facilities confined his objection to a single sentence: the money should go to roofs, not memories. A young lecturer arrived late with an infant on her shoulder. The baby made a small sound, and the room softened

by a degree. Alvarez felt guilty for noticing. Reaching for the water pitcher, he banged his elbow on the table edge, and the bang ended the argument more effectively than anything he had said. Someone made an oral motion to postpone; it failed by four votes. Through the window, a gang of crows had taken over the parking lot.

Afterward they ate roast chicken on the slope behind East Hall. The plan was not identical to what he had proposed — the housing would be smaller, the timeline longer — but it was close enough. Alvarez thought about evolution: institutions change the way species do, by adjustments nobody notices until the shape is altogether different. He had been a magnet for complaints for two decades, and now, on the incline of his last year, he felt something like generosity from people he had argued with. The feeling was not universal — Hollis had already gone home — but it was enough for one evening. They walked onward toward the parking lot. Somewhere under the grass was a man nobody remembered, and the roots of the old trees were nourishing him still.

解析 · 行间留白，可直接手写

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译文

在最后一次院务会议的前夜，阿尔瓦雷斯院长又读了一遍手册。在行政部门待了二十二年，他早已明白，恰当的那句话很少是真实的那句。三周前他发出过一个信号，写在一份抽象到只有两个人声称看得懂的备忘录里。他的雇主不是一个人，而是一套程序，而这些程序开会的次数比他频繁得多。六十八岁的他学会了用被动语态说话，也学会了提前到场。他合上书，关掉台灯，在黑暗里坐了一会儿。楼里很安静。楼下某处，一扇门关上了。

九点，他站起来，把方案推销给委员会。东楼空了六年，可以改造成研究生住房：四十个小单元，一个共用厨房，暖气能用。估价是巨大的——八百万——但替代方案是拆除，价格几乎相同，而拆除什么都不会留下。仅公用事业费用每年都在上涨，涨幅略微超过预算允许的范围。他没有提前宣传这个想法，因为一宣传就会把它杀死；高效的路径是先让数字说话。他把一页纸的摘要沿着桌子传下去，然后等着。有好一会儿，没有人拿起来。

东楼曾是他母亲的楼。她在那里工作了三十年，去世后，他从她的办公室继承了一座小小的古董钟。它至今还放在他的抽屉里，每周一他给它上弦。这个地方有一种报告装不下的个性，也有一种任何估价都捕捉不到的心理重量。它以一种未完成之事特有的方式萦绕着他。它似乎还有自己的意识——至少在清晨六点，暖气片敲响、走廊里飘着粉笔味的时候是这样。1958 年，楼后曾有过一次葬礼，一位从未被记录的场地管理员；他母亲说起他时，有一种独特的方式，既温柔又就事论事。

投票的过程很残酷。两位成员抵制了一个小时，其中设施部的霍利斯把反对意见限制在一句话里：钱应该花在屋顶上，不是记忆上。一位年轻讲师迟到了，肩上抱着一个婴儿。孩子发出一点小小的声音，房间就缓和了一度。阿尔瓦雷斯因为注意到这一点而感到内疚。他伸手去拿水壶，肘部撞在桌沿上，那声砰响结束争论的效果，比他说的任何话都好。有人提出口头动议要求推迟，以四票之差被否决。窗外，一群乌鸦已经占领了停车场。

之后，他们在东楼后面的山坡上吃烤鸡。方案和他提议的并不完全相同——住房更小，时间更长——但已经足够接近。阿尔瓦雷斯想到了进化：机构改变的方式和物种一样，靠没人注意的调整，直到形状完全不同。二十年来，他一直是指向他的投诉的磁铁；如今，在最后一年的斜坡上，他从那些和他争论过的人身上感到某种类似慷慨的东西。这种感觉并不普遍——霍利斯已经回家了——但对一个晚上来说足够了。他们继续朝停车场走去。草地下面某个地方，埋着一个没人记得的人，老树的根仍在滋养着他。